

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's big push to Make In India could be seen as a fertile bed for the maker movement. According to a World Economic Forum report, manufacturing currently contributes approximately 14.2% to India's total GDP, which is lower than other emerging economies recognised for delivering significant competitive advantages for manufacturers, including China (32.4%). In 2011, India announced its National Manufacturing Policy with an objective to increasing manufacturing sector growth to 2-4% more than GDP growth. To do this they planned to increase manufacturing's share of GDP to 25% by 2025. According to their estimates, it promised to create 100 million new jobs by the same deadline.

For a country that comes with a rich skillset of handicrafts, the maker movement is the new wave cottage industry at play. Modi's move for India to be seen as a competitive manufacturing and production hub rather than just a service oriented nation with cheap workforce. In the same vein, makerspaces are seen as mini production units, a nursery for consumer goods and a place where more students are trained practically to transform them to a skilled workforce.

Heavyweights like Maker Media seem to be behind the proliferation of the maker culture in India. This is evident from their backing festivals like Maker Fest which will celebrate their second edition later this month in Ahmedabad; 30,000 spectators have already signed up, and the first edition of Mini Maker Faire was held in Bangalore last year.

It may seem like a loaded movement to be a part of but visit a makerspace and you are more likely to find yourself in a playground for grownups. Makers aren't nearly as menacing when you see them racing RC cars, whizzing drones, manoeuvring hovercrafts, 3D printing minions, etc. And of course, there's Bob — the robot that likes to dance. 